Prompt (visitor): 🗺️ Plan a 3-day itinerary based in Fort Myers — Beaches, Nature & wildlife, Family / kids

Sunny Days & Wild Ways: A 3-Day Fort Myers Family Escape

Welcome to Fort Myers! March is a fantastic time to visit—the weather is typically mild and dry, perfect for outdoor exploration. This itinerary balances relaxing beach time with unique Southwest Florida nature experiences that kids will love. Having a rental car is highly recommended for getting around the region easily.

Day 1: Coastal Wonders

Morning: J.N. "Ding" Darling National Wildlife Refuge (Sanibel). Explore this world-famous refuge via the 4-mile Wildlife Drive. It's excellent for spotting birds, alligators, and sometimes manatees. ($)

Afternoon: Fort Myers Beach. Head back to the mainland for classic white-sand fun. The area is bustling with family-friendly activities and easy beach access. (Free)

Evening: Dinner in the Fort Myers Beach area to enjoy the sunset over the Gulf.

Day 2: Nature & Discovery

Morning: Six Mile Cypress Slough Preserve. Walk the 1.2-mile elevated boardwalk through protected wetlands. It's stroller-friendly, shaded, and great for spotting turtles and wading birds. (Free)

Afternoon: Wonder Gardens (Bonita Springs). A historic, intimate attraction where kids can see rescued birds, reptiles, and lush botanical displays. ($$)

Evening: Relaxed dinner at a local family diner.

Day 3: Beach Relaxation & Local Flavor

Morning: Lovers Key State Park. A quieter, more natural beach experience. Take the tram to the beach and look for shells or go for a gentle swim. ($)

Afternoon: Calusa Nature Center & Planetarium. Perfect for a change of pace; visit the butterfly house and catch a planetarium show. ($)

Evening: Farewell dinner at a local favorite.

Where to eat

- FK Your Diet: Famous for hearty, comfort-food breakfasts and lunches. ($)
- Farmer's Market Restaurant: A local institution serving classic Southern-style cooking. ($)
- Mel's Diner: Fun '50s-style atmosphere with a menu that pleases even the pickiest eaters. ($)

Practical tips

- **Sun & Heat:** Even in March, the Florida sun is strong. Wear hats, sunglasses, and high-SPF sunscreen. Drink plenty of water.
- **Red Tide:** Before heading to the beach, check the Florida Fish and Wildlife Conservation Commission (FWC) Red Tide report to ensure water quality is good.
- **Traffic:** Traffic can be heavy, especially around bridges to the islands (Sanibel/Fort Myers Beach). Plan to leave early in the morning.
- **Parking:** Many beach parks charge a parking fee; bring a credit card.
- **Hurricane Season:** While March is outside of hurricane season (June–Nov), always monitor local news if you see storm alerts.

Sources

- Lee County Parks & Recreation
- Florida State Parks
- U.S. Fish & Wildlife Service (Ding Darling)
- FWC Red Tide Status

Verified places (Google Maps)

#	Place	Rating	Address	Map
1	J.N. "Ding" Darling National Wildlife Refuge	★ 4.6 (1,087)	1 Wildlife Dr, Sanibel, FL 33957, USA	Open
2	Fort Myers Beach	★ 4.6 (1,678)	Fort Myers Beach, 950 Estero Blvd, Fort Myers Beach, FL 33931, USA	Open
3	Six Mile Cypress Slough Preserve	★ 4.8 (4,660)	7751 Penzance Blvd, Fort Myers, FL 33966, USA	Open
4	Wonder Gardens	★ 4.4 (2,293)	27180 Old 41 Rd, Bonita Springs, FL 34135, USA	Open
5	Lovers Key State Park	★ 4.7 (7,540)	8700 Estero Blvd, Fort Myers Beach, FL 33931, USA	Open
6	Calusa Nature Center & Planetarium	★ 4.2 (654)	3450 Ortiz Ave, Fort Myers, FL 33905, USA	Open
7	FK Your Diet Fort Myers	★ 4.7 (1,931)	19630 S Tamiami Trl, Fort Myers, FL 33908, USA	Open
8	Farmer's Market Restaurant	★ 4.6 (3,145)	2736 Edison Ave, Fort Myers, FL 33916, USA	Open
9	Mel's Diner - Fort Myers	★ 4.4 (5,188)	4820 S Cleveland Ave, Fort Myers, FL 33907, USA	Open

You might also ask

- Are there any kid-friendly boat tours to see manatees or dolphins nearby?
- What are the best rainy day activities in Fort Myers for families?
- Do I need to book parking in advance for Sanibel Island or Lovers Key?

▶ Agent steps

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